

Drive ‘em Crazy

We call up the best wheels and race them against each other to the finish line

The wheel caters to a very small category of gamers as it can only be used with high-speed racing simulators. This was the only category that saw a very limited competition with no product from Microsoft and only one Logitech high-end product. Saitek, Frontech and Typhoon managed to fill in the gaps with some good, some bad and some strictly ordinary wheels. The cheapest wheel was from Typhoon, while the ones from Logitech and Saitek stole the lime light for being expensive.

Test process

We tested all the gaming devices on our test-bench comprising a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz on an MSI 845E MAX2 BLR motherboard, 256 MB DDR RAM and a 40 GB Seagate ATA IV 7,200-rpm hard drive running Windows XP. The devices were tested on four primary parameters: features, ergonomics, build quality and value for money. Each parameter was assigned 25 per cent weightage. The overall scores were then calculated from how much the device scored in each area.

Features: For evaluating the features of every wheel, we took into account various parameters such as the interface of the device. A device with a USB interface scored higher than that with a game port interface. The presence of both analog and digital controllers fetched some extra points. More the number of programmable buttons, more were the points awarded to the product; floor pedals as against hand paddles for gas and brake functions made for brownie points. Features such as rumble effects and force feedback were awarded extra points.

Ergonomics: To calculate the ergonomics of the wheel, we took into account various criteria such as the size of the steering wheel and its grip. Wheels with a recess for the thumb and rubberised steering scored more than the ones without them. The button layout was also considered when awarding points—a better layout, with well-placed buttons scored more. Points were also awarded for the feel of the floor pedals, depending on their designed and pivot angle.

Build quality: Wheels by their very nature are huge and sturdy. We awarded points for the quality of materials used, the quality of the joints and their overall build. The but-



- Go for a wheel with floor pedals over a hand-mounted one for a more realistic gaming experience.
- The length of the floor cable should be enough to connect to the main steering wheel and must be detachable for portability.
- The clamping mechanism of the wheel should be strong enough to hold the wheel in position, so ensure that your wheel of choice has a proper clamping device.
- The wheel should ideally have four programmable buttons and wheel mounted gear paddles for shifting the gears, apart from the floor pedals for gas and brakes.
- A force feedback wheel may be a good investment in thrill but it does come at a price. Consider it only if you are likely to play every racing game released.

tons were awarded points based on tactility and tackiness. The wheel with an anti-skid floor board was given more points. Also, the wheel with good clamping mechanism scored more.

Frontech Adventure Wheel

Features: Rumble effects, wheel mounted gas, brake pedals, 10 programmable buttons, one D-pad, floor gas and brake pedals
Price: Rs 1,600 **Contact:** Jupiter Infosys India Ltd
Phone: 022-2001211/2001212 **E-mail:** frontech@bom 5.vsnl.net.in **Web site:** www.frontechonline.com

This was the only wheel with rumble effects in the entire comparison. The Adventure sports a D-pad, and hand-gas and brake pedals. The steering wheel has three spokes with a clean button layout. The base is light and four suction cups hold the wheel in place. A toggle switch allows you to choose between the wheel and the D-pad. The rumble effects are precise, but failing to configure it properly makes it vibrate continuously. Rumble effects, 10 programmable buttons, a D-pad and a choice between hand or floor pedals for the gas and brake, for just Rs 1,650 make it irresistible.



Frontech Adventure Wheel		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Logitech WingMan Formula Force

Features: Force feedback effects, wheel mounted gear switches, four programmable buttons, floor brake, gear pedals
Price: Rs 6,999
Contact: Aditya Infotech Ltd **Phone:** 022-26338555 **E-mail:** sunil_zarekar@adityagroup.com **Web site:** www.logitech.com

The WingMan Formula Force GP is one of the best wheels we've seen. The build quality is rugged and the red rubber grips make the wheel non-slippery. The gear paddles are done away with and the touch-and-go switches are placed just underneath the spokes. The other four buttons are mounted on the facing surface of the spokes. The foot pedal is connected to the main unit via a small RJ45-like pin and uses a high-quality spring that provides an excellent response. It sports a slip-free design and is pivoted at right angles for comfort gaming. The Formula Force GP provides excellent force feedback with commendable accuracy and precision. This wheel has it all—good ergonomics, ample force feedback effects coupled with ease of use.



Logitech WingMan Formula Force GP		A-
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	